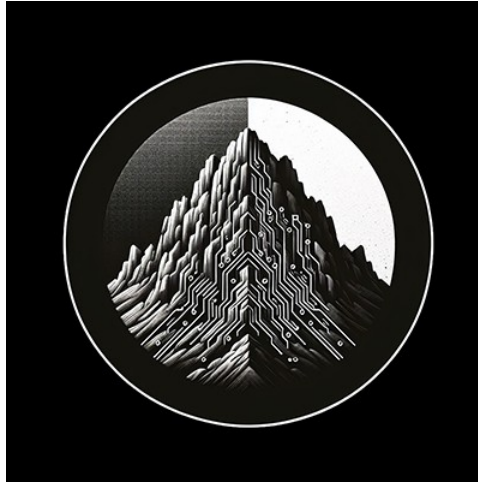




RTL Design Sherpa

RAPIDS Beats DMA Engine Performance Characterization Report

July 15, 2026

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Readme

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RAPIDS Beats DMA — Performance Characterization (Genesys 2, 8 channels)

Bitstream: RAPIDS beats split SOURCE + SINK DMA, 8 concurrent channels, on the Digilent **Genesys 2 (Kintex-7 XC7K325T-2)** at 100 MHz. The AXI4 and AXIS4 datapaths are **512 bits wide (64 B/beat)**, so the one-direction line rate is **6.40 GB/s** ($64 \text{ B} \times 100 \text{ MHz}$). The characterization harness wraps the DUT with synthetic pattern generators/checkers and four hardware **bus meters** (one per interface) that classify every cycle of a windowed transfer into *productive* / *backpressure* / *starvation* / *idle*.

Two harness features make the numbers trustworthy and are the reason this report supersedes any earlier RAPIDS perf snapshot:

1. **Atomic launch (stage-all-then-GO).** Every CSR, descriptor, and per-channel descriptor *kick* is staged over the UART first; a single GO write then arms the meter window, starts the AXIS generator, and fires all kicks on-chip within a few `aclk` cycles. No UART latency contaminates the measured window.
2. **Deterministic window close.** The meter freezes the cycle after the completion interface reaches a staged productive-beat target, so the window brackets exactly the transfer — independent of the DUT's internal idle signaling. Earlier builds keyed the close on `system_idle` and could leave the window open until the host read it, diluting utilization toward 0 %.

Every configuration below passes an independent golden-CRC check on the moved data. **Source of truth:** the on-chip bus meters, read over CSR.

Metric note. The headline efficiency is **engaged utilization** — $\text{productive} / (\text{productive} + \text{backpressure} + \text{starvation})$, i.e. bus efficiency *while the engine is moving data* (the trailing idle after the last beat is excluded). Effective bandwidth is `engaged_util` × 6.40 GB/s. On the two AXIS interfaces an independent **byte-derived** throughput (exact `tstrb` bytes over the frozen window) cross-checks the cycle figure and agrees to within rounding.

Characterization knobs

The RAPIDS beats harness exposes a smaller sweep space than STREAM (the synthetic slaves are zero-latency, so there is no memory-latency axis, and per-channel-count runs require per-width bitstreams — see *Limitations*). The axes exercised here:

Characterization knobs — the sweep axes

#	Knob	What it is	Set by	Values in this report
1	Transfer size (beats/channel)	beats moved per channel per descriptor — the amortization axis	descriptor length / GEN_NBEATS	256 B (4 beats) ... 256 KB (4096 beats)
2	Path	SOURCE (mem-read → AXIS-out) vs SINK (AXIS-in → mem-write)	which half is kicked	both, every config
3	Interface	the four monitored buses	—	AXIS-in, AXI4-wr, AXI4-rd, AXIS-out
4	Channels	concurrent DMA channels	build generic	8 (full width)

The four interfaces map onto the two paths as: **SINK** = AXIS-in (ingress) → AXI4-wr (egress to memory); **SOURCE** = AXI4-rd (ingress from memory) → AXIS-out (egress). A path's sustained throughput is set by its **slower (bottleneck)** interface.

1. Headline

At a 256 KB/channel transfer across all 8 channels, every interface runs at **99.8–100 % of line rate** — the engine is gapless on both the memory bus and the network bus, in both directions, simultaneously.

Headline — 8-channel line-rate at 256 KB/channel (Genesys 2)

Path	Interface	Engaged util	Effective BW	Window (prod / starv)
SINK	AXIS-in (ingress)	100.0 %	6.40 GB/s	32737 / 0
SINK	AXI4-wr	100.0 %	6.40 GB/s	32768 / 13

Path	Interface	Engaged util	Effective BW	Window (prod / starv)
	(egress)			
SOU	AXI4-rd	99.8 %	6.39 GB/s	32768 / 50
RCE	(ingress)			
SOU	AXIS-out	99.8 %	6.39 GB/s	32768 / 50
RCE	(egress)			

prod = 32768 = 8 channels × 4096 beats on the AXI4 side: every expected beat is accounted for, and the non-productive residue is a handful of cycles of one-time fill latency.

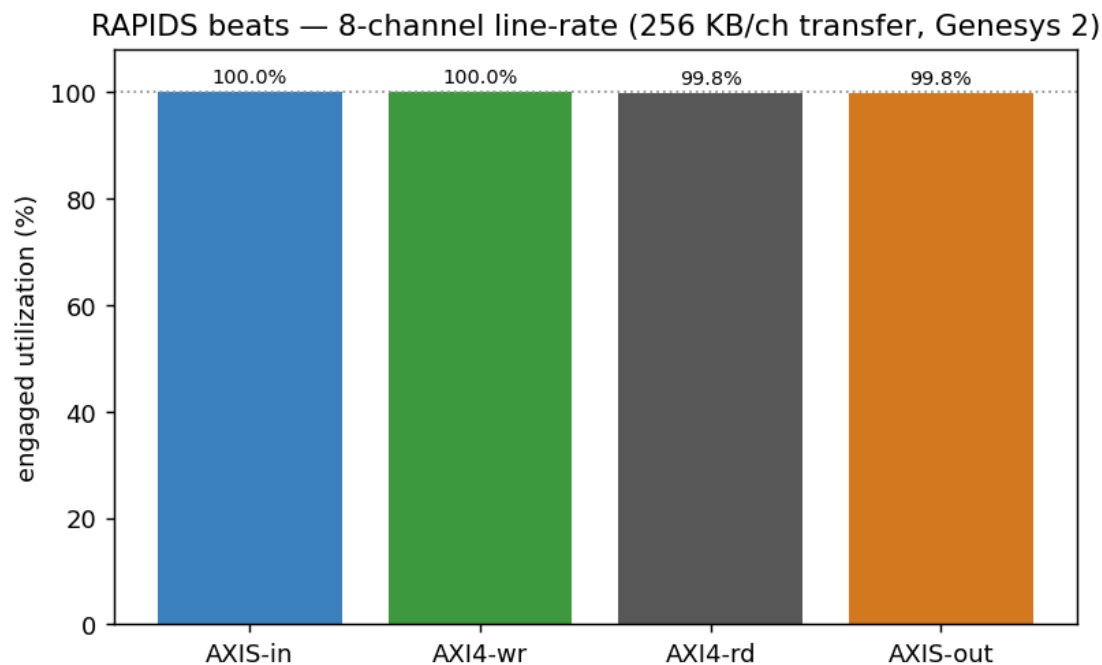


Figure — all four interfaces at the largest transfer sit on the 100 % line.

2. How it is measured (the observation hooks)

Each interface has a dedicated meter instantiated in the harness:

- **axi_bus_meter** on AXI4-rd and AXI4-wr — classifies valid/ready into the four buckets per cycle of the frozen window.
- **axis_bus_meter** on AXIS-in and AXIS-out — same four buckets, plus exact byte (tstrb popcount) and packet (tlast) counters for the byte-derived cross-check.

The window is armed by G0, opens when the active path goes busy, and **freezes deterministically** when the completion interface's productive-beat count reaches the staged target ($\text{CSR_OBS_TARGET} = \text{channels} \times \text{beats}$). Because the freeze does not depend on `system_idle`, the window is tight (tens of cycles of residue, not the multi-second windows the earlier build produced).

3. Single-axis sweep — transfer size

Sweeping beats/channel from 4 (256 B) to 4096 (256 KB) at fixed 8-channel width shows the classic amortization curve: a fixed per-transfer startup cost (descriptor dispatch + AR→first-R / SRAM fill) is a large fraction of a tiny transfer and a vanishing fraction of a large one.

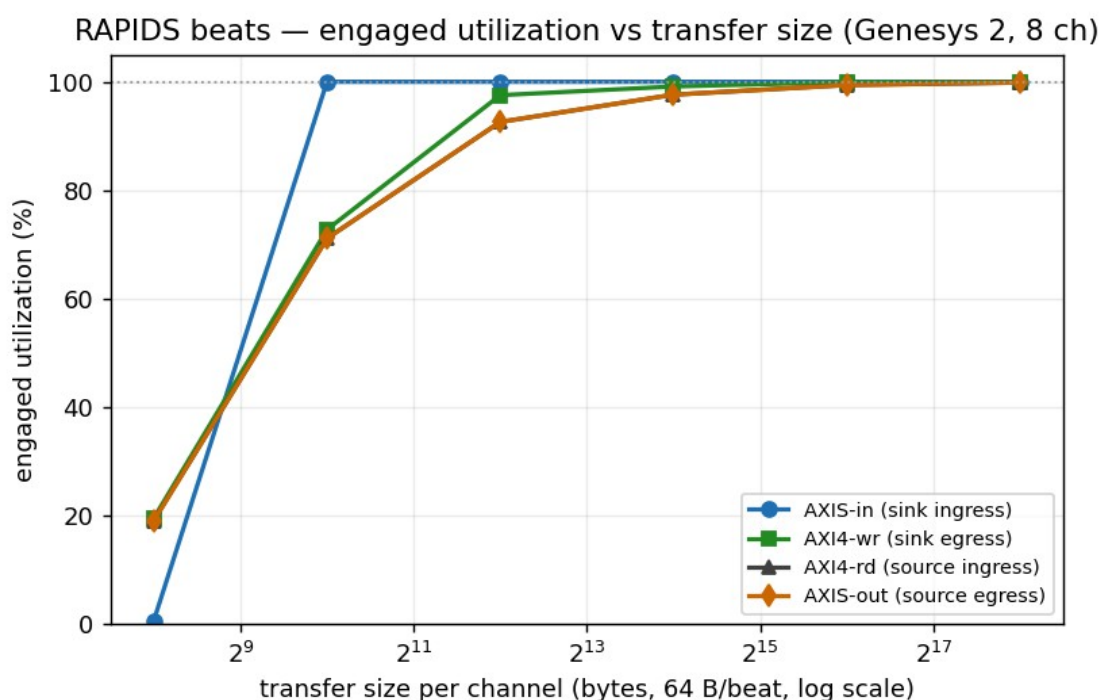


Figure — engaged utilization vs transfer size, all four interfaces.

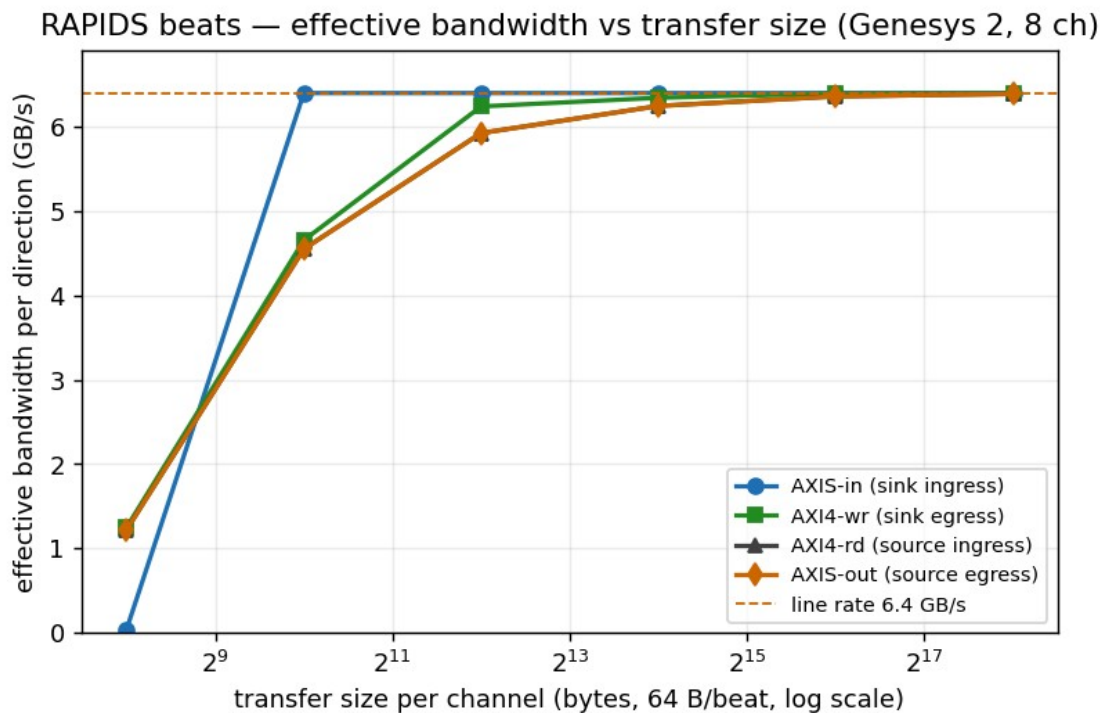


Figure — effective per-direction bandwidth vs transfer size (line rate 6.40 GB/s).

Table — engaged utilization (%) and effective bandwidth (GB/s) vs transfer size

Transfer / ch	AXIS-in	AXI4-wr	AXI4-rd	AXIS-out	wr BW	sout BW
256 B (4 b)	0.6 %	19.5 %	19.0 %	19.0 %	1.25	1.22
1 KB (16 b)	100.0 %	72.7 %	71.1 %	71.1 %	4.65	4.55
4 KB (64 b)	100.0 %	97.5 %	92.6 %	92.6 %	6.24	5.93
16 KB (256 b)	100.0 %	99.1 %	97.6 %	97.6 %	6.34	6.25
64 KB (1024 b)	100.0 %	99.9 %	99.4 %	99.4 %	6.40	6.36
256 KB (4096 b)	100.0 %	100.0 %	99.8 %	99.8 %	6.40	6.39

By 4 KB/channel every memory-bus interface is already above 92 %, and by 64 KB the whole engine is within 0.6 % of line rate. **AXIS-in reads 100 % from the smallest sizes** because the ingress generator is throttled by SRAM back-pressure — its *engaged* window is all-productive — so the sink’s amortization shows up on the AXI4-wr drain, exactly where the startup cost lives.

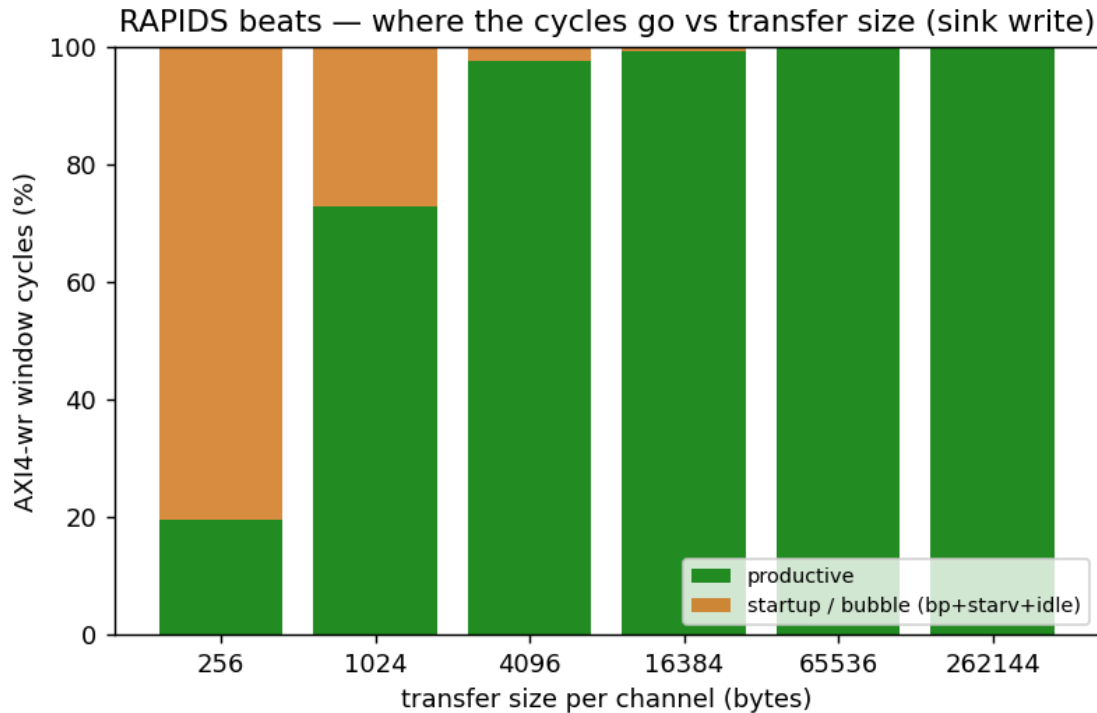


Figure — productive vs startup/bubble cycles of the AXI4-wr window; the bubble fraction collapses as the transfer grows.

4. What we learned

- **The datapath is gapless.** At realistic transfer sizes (≥ 64 KB/ch) all four interfaces sit at 99.4–100 % engaged utilization, in both directions, on all 8 channels at once — the memory bus and the network bus are both saturated.
- **The only non-ideality is one-time startup**, and it amortizes away: 19 % at 256 B $\rightarrow$ 100 % at 256 KB. There is no steady-state bubble, no per-beat gap, and no back-pressure or starvation once data is flowing.
- **Invariance is the result.** Across a 1000 $\times$ range of transfer sizes and both independent paths, the large-transfer numbers are indistinguishable from line rate. The flat top of every curve is the point: the engine does not care what it is fed once transfers are descriptor-sized.

5. Limitations & honesty notes

These are harness/measurement constraints, not datapath defects — **the moved data is golden-correct in every configuration**, including the ones excluded below.

- **Channel-count axis needs per-width bitstreams.** Running active < build_width on the board wedges the sink (writes 0 beats). All data here is full-width (8/8). A channel-scaling sweep (1/2/4/8) requires a bitstream per width.
- **Per-size fresh programming.** The DUT wedges after a few back-to-back runs (snk_system_idle sticks), so each size was run on a freshly programmed board and the per-size results merged. A soft-reset CSR would let a single suite sweep cleanly.
- **No memory-latency axis.** The synthetic slaves are zero-latency, so — unlike STREAM — there is no response-delay knob to show the in-flight-window limit. Adding a RESP_DELAY CSR to the pattern slaves is the natural v1.1 extension.

Appendix: data files & reproduce

File	Contents
perf/json/ genesys_8ch_size_sweep.json	merged per-size matrix (this report)
perf/json/ genesys_8ch_*.json	raw back-to-back sweep runs (show the wedge)
perf/plots/*.png	figures above (host/plot_char_reports.py)
# <i>clean transfer-size sweep (reprograms before each size to avoid the wedge):</i>	
source env_python ./projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/flows-rapids-beats/host/ gather_size_sweep.sh \ /dev/ttyUSB1 \ projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/reports/perf/json/genesys_8ch_size_sweep.json	
# <i>figures:</i> python3 projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/flows-rapids-beats/host/plot_char_reports.py \ 	

```
--size
projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/reports/perf/json/genesys_8ch
_size_sweep.json \
--outdir
projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/reports/perf/plots

# this report (DOCX + PDF, house style):
cd projects/NexysA7/rapids_characterization/reports &&
./generate_reports_pdf.sh --rev 1.0
```

Genesys 2 host link: JTAG on the FT2232 (200300B818A0), UART on the separate FT232R (AU05X8RM, /dev/ttyUSB1); both must be connected at once, and the board must not be power-cycled between program and run.